Sanchi had little doubt that some of Ashoka's visits to Buddhist places of pilgrimage were interwoven with the various stories carved on parts of the Sanchi monuments, and it is on their judgement that we must rely.

The southern gateway (or torana) of the great stupa, for instance, shows Ashoka's visit to the Ramagrama stupa.[18] In the *Ashokavadana* account he had travelled there to take possession of one of the original relic deposits of the Buddha. Ashoka is shown with the royal insignia—a turban, ewer, and fly whisk, the traditional umbrella being absent—on a chariot in an impressive procession including elephants and arms-bearing troops. The sculpted narrative—dominated by hooded Nagas and Nagis worshipping the stupa—also tells us that the Nagas resisted Ashoka and successfully circumvented his quest to dig out the relics. The southern gateway's western pillar shows the same royal personage, but quite differently: this time on his visit to the Bodhi tree.[19] The sacred tree was, as we saw in the *Ashokavadana's* account of the unhappy last years, dying out because of the jealous ignorance of Queen Tishyarakshita. So Ashoka is not here a king leading a regal procession but a figure of sorrow evoking sympathy. He is supported by two queens and seems about to swoon with grief (Fig. Epilogue 1). Above this, another panel shows the Bodhi tree, decorated with streamers and a crowning umbrella and surrounded by a temple—presumably the one Ashoka built. The same sort of representation, and of the same period, can be seen on another stupa at Sanchi (Stupa 2). This is halfway down the hill on which the great stupa stands, its railing adorned by many carvings. One of these is of Ashoka supported by his two queens and surrounded by attendants carrying the insignias of royalty.[20]